

Aaron Scherf

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Over 7 years of experience implementing international development, foreign policy, data analytics, and applied empirical research. Led monitoring and evaluation for multi-billion dollar portfolios in Ukraine and Colombia, including cross-cutting design, budgeting, and stakeholder communication. Technical specializations in statistical analysis, geospatial technology, data visualization, and impact evaluation.

WORK EXPERIENCE

U.S. Agency for International Development

05/2019 – 07/2025

Foreign Service Officer – Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning Team Lead (FS 3–5)

Kyiv, Ukraine

- Supervised \$36M contract for monitoring, evaluation, and learning services, including developing new systems for performance tracking, strategy alignment, and context research.
- Co-created third-party monitoring system which conducted over 3,000 verification visits in a year.
- Supervised implementation of 20 program evaluations, including leading design of a \$1.5M randomized control trial to evaluate impact of \$450M credit facilitation program for small businesses.
- Simplified in-person monitoring visit process for staff, enabling expansion from 20 oversight visits per quarter to over 100, despite warzone conditions.
- Led collection of annual performance metrics and sectoral narratives for 52 development programs, aligning inter-agency indicator framework with new countrywide strategy and scorecard.
- Supervised four experienced technical experts in monitoring, evaluation, learning, and knowledge management.
- Developed organizational knowledge management plan and designed 12 context assessments to prepare for new country strategy, covering gender and ethnic minority inclusion.
- Led team of 15 staff as acting Office Director and Budget Lead for 3 months during \$1.7Bn congressional funding negotiations and supervised over \$60M in realignment of program funds.
- Mentored 220 staff on applications of artificial intelligence and data analytics platforms to improve program delivery and performance reporting.
- Developed analytics system to track \$5Bn in electrical infrastructure support by administrative geography, enabling rapid repairs in response to Russian missile strikes and increased accountability.

Foreign Service Officer – MEL and Program Design Officer (FS 4–9)

Bogota, Colombia

- Supported 32 programs to re-align performance indicators with gender equity and social inclusion principles, including multiple presentations to contract partner teams in Spanish.
- Led the design process for four new programs in smallholder agriculture, environmental conservation, and rural land titling, including developing indicators to measure job-expanding policy reforms.
- Developed data system to process and classify high-resolution drone imagery, resulting in over 600 new land titles issued to smallholder farmers in flood-prone areas in first 6 months.
- Led country-level FY24 presidential budget request for \$413 million.
- Led collection of over 500 performance indicators across 32 development programs for annual report.
- Advised 30+ programs on gender equity and social inclusion, with focus on Venezuelan migrants.

Foreign Service Officer – Program Officer (FS 5–12)

Washington, DC, USA

- Supported annual performance review and budgeting processes for Honduras office, revising dozens of key issue narratives and performance indicator justifications.
- Won annual agency-wide award for developing budget data processing and visualization tool using Python and Tableau, saving hundreds of hours of staff time in negotiations with State Department.
- Led knowledge management pilot program with South Sudan office, including designing staff transition resources and implementation plan for improving handovers and file management in Juba.

Monitoring and Evaluation Specialist (Visiting Fellow)**Pretoria, South Africa**

- Authored 200-page regional Gender Analysis report for 7 countries, synthesizing research on conditions for women, people with disabilities, and LGBTQI+ persons in Southern Africa.
- Revised evaluation methodology for 12 regional programs to improve validity of performance metrics.
- Supported real-time data analytics for PEPFAR programs focused on HIV/AIDS epidemic in 7 countries.

Berkeley Food Institute**09/2019 – 03/2020****Agriculture and Hydrology Research Analyst****Berkeley, CA, USA**

- Developed geospatial model analyzing groundwater and rainfall data compared with agricultural land-use for California's Central Valley, to support legislative reform and job-expansion programs.

University of California, Berkeley**08/2018 – 05/2020****Graduate Student Instructor****Berkeley, CA, USA**

- MATH 10A – Methods of Mathematics: Calculus, Linear Algebra, and Combinatorics: Independently taught 52 undergraduates across two seminars and office hours.
- PP 297 – Stata for Public Policy Analysis: Designed and taught empirical research methods in Stata seminar for 40 MPP and MPA students, including research support for capstone projects.
- DATA 100 – Principals and Techniques of Data Science: Developed and taught labs on intermediate data science techniques in Python for undergraduates, including office hours and project support.
- DS 421 – Data Science Applications for Environmental Science: Coached team of 4 doctoral students on data science research projects on forest management practices for post-fire vegetation recovery

Centre for European Economic Research (ZEW)**11/2017 – 07/2018****Graduate Research Fellow – Migration and Labor Economics****Mannheim, Germany**

- Designed primary survey to assess language acquisition, education, and labor force participation of asylum seekers in the Rhine-Neckar region.
- Linked data to nationwide longitudinal survey of migrants in Germany by geographic disaggregates using Stata.
- Conducted statistical analysis of asylum seekers' education level and living conditions relation to employment outcomes using advanced econometric methods in Stata and data calls in SQL.
- Co-authored research paper in German on policy reform for refugee job placement in Rhine-Neckar region. Presented in German to city councils in Heidelberg and Mannheim.

U.S. House of Representatives**05/2017 – 08/2017****Policy Analyst – Congressman Crowley and House Democratic Caucus****Washington, DC, USA**

- Created financial model to analyze differential impacts by age bracket of proposed retirement savings bill, to prepare Democratic Caucus members for debate.
- Wrote 6 briefings on policy issues for review by the representative, discussing new sanctions on Russia and the Technology Modernization Fund.
- Analyzed constituency data to improve outreach by the Caucus office.

Historic Macon Foundation**08/2016 – 05/2017****Real Estate Analyst****Macon, GA, USA**

- Analyzed impact of historic revitalization investments on property values through econometric assessment.
- Supported Neighborhood Incubator community program to develop local leadership capacity.

Tembeka Social Investment Company**06/2016 – 08/2016****Microfinance Analyst****Cape Town, South Africa**

- Analyzed financial performance of micro-enterprise investment portfolio to generate annual report for shareholders and board of directors.
- Researched legislative reforms to small business tax and investment regulations to support local entrepreneurs.
- Assisted small business client management and business development for social investment portfolio.

Bloomfield Community Empowerment Center
Economic Analyst

10/2015 – 05/2016
Macon

- Collected socioeconomic data on local neighborhood through census and tax assessor files.
- Developed neighborhood revitalization strategy centered on resident participation and presented to county commission.
- Presented research methodology and results of strategy at Clinton Global Initiative University 2016, under Commitment to Action "Collect to Connect: Bloomfield Community Asset Analysis".

NewTown Macon
Urban Development Researcher

05/2014 – 08/2014
Macon, GA

- Collected primary survey data on parking patterns in downtown Macon.
- Analyzed parking data using geographic information systems (GIS) and statistical analysis to develop recommendations for improved street infrastructure and traffic management plans.
- Surveyed 45 local business owners on Community Improvement District tax plans.

LandLink Analytic Services, LLC
Co-Founder, Lead Economist

12/2016 – 10/2018
Macon, GA, USA

- Founded data analytics consulting company with team of economists and software engineers to develop geospatial models of housing price dynamics and identify areas at increased risk of gentrification.
- Conducted 7 contracted research projects analyzing impact of public and private property investment on housing prices and municipal tax revenues.

EDUCATION

Columbia University

PhD in Sustainable Development

New York, NY, USA • 08/2026 – Present

Georgia Institute of Technology

Master of Science in Computer Science • GPA: 3.88

Atlanta, GA, USA • 01/2022 – 08/2026

Specialization in machine learning, artificial intelligence, and AI ethics

Indiana State University

Master of Science in Mathematics • GPA: 3.85

Terre Haute, IN, USA • 05/2021 – 05/2024

Thesis: Novel Omnibus Normality Test and Power Comparison with the Shapiro-Wilk

University of California, Berkeley

Master of Science in Development Practice • GPA: 3.94

Berkeley, CA, USA • 07/2018 – 05/2020

Thesis: Predicting the Yield of CIMMYT Wheat Genotypes via Remote Sensing and Machine Learning

Heidelberg University

Master of Science (audited) in Economics

Heidelberg, DE • 07/2017 – 06/2018

Courses included advanced econometrics, land monitoring and classification, advanced mathematics for economics, and big data in economics, plus courses in German and Arabic.

Mercer University

Bachelor in International Finance and Economics • GPA: 3.91

Macon, GA, USA • 08/2013 – 05/2017

Exchange Semester at Linnaeus University in Kalmar, Sweden

Honors Thesis: Analyzing Regional Economic Impacts of Syrian Refugee Crisis in Turkey

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Donald M. Payne International Development Fellow (\$100,000 graduate fellowship)

05/2017

Humanity in Action Senior Fellow (in partnership with Amnesty International)

05/2017

Fulbright Scholar (Graduate Research Fellow in Heidelberg, DE)	05/2017
Stamps Foundation Leadership Scholar (\$240,000 undergraduate scholarship)	05/2013

RESEARCH PRESENTATIONS & PUBLICATIONS

Autonomous Drone Deployment Grid for Improved Wildfire Response in California UC Berkeley: Innovations in Disaster Response Showcase	05/2020
Applications of PCA for Mapping Regional Socioeconomic Vulnerability Indices UC Berkeley: Data for Human Mobility Lab	12/2019
Integration Progress: Results from two Reallabor Surveys of Asylum Seekers Centre for European Economic Research (ZEW) Published at: https://www.econstor.eu/handle/10419/231442	08/2018
The End of Schengen? Reforms to the Dublin Regulation and EU Asylum Policy Humanity in Action International Conference in Strasbourg, FR	08/2017
National Conference on Undergraduate Research Gentrification or Revitalization? Ethical Investment in Urban Property Development	04/2017
Economic Impact Assessment of Historic Property Rehabilitation in Macon, GA Society of Business, Industry, and Economics Conference	04/2017
"OurBlock" – Blockchain Based Property Registry for South African Land Reform Harvard Social Entrepreneurship Pitch Competition	03/2017
"How to Kill a Microfinance Fund" – Analysis of Microcredit Policy in South Africa Southern Conference Undergraduate Research Forum	10/2016
"Peer2Peer" – Digital Marketplace for Asset-Collateralized Microcredit Exchange Thomson Reuters' "Land Rights in Africa" Hackathon and Pitch Contest	06/2016
"Bloomfield 2020" – Neighborhood Economic Development Plan Clinton Global Initiative University at Berkeley, CA	04/2016

SKILLS

Computer Programming

- Python, R, JavaScript
- Stata, MatLab, Excel
- Data Engineering
- SQL, Azure, GCP
- Agentic AI (CrewAI / AutoGen)
- Natural Language Processing
- Data Visualization and Analysis
- Artificial Neural Networks
- Machine Learning
- Large Language Models
- Cloud Architecture (GCP / Azure)
- RAG AI (LangChain)
- Google Earth Engine / GCP
- Tableau and PowerBI
- Data Collection & Processing

Applied Economic Research

- GIS Analysis (ArcGIS / GEE)
- Economic Data Analysis
- Applied Econometrics
- Environmental Analysis
- Empirical Policy Analysis
- International Economics
- Econometric Modeling
- Development Economics
- Causal Impact Evaluation
- Remote Sensing
- Survey Design / Distribution
- Statistical Modeling
- Data Visualization
- Demographic Survey Analysis
- Cost Effectiveness Analysis
- Data Visualization and Analysis
- Impact Evaluation
- Development Economics

Languages and Other

- Spanish – Professional
- German – Intermediate
- Ukrainian – Elementary
- Program Monitoring
- Project Management
- Program Evaluation
- Contract Management
- Budget Management
- Report and Memo Writing
- Congressional Allocations
- Government Accountability
- Stakeholder Engagement
- Presentations and Training
- Development Program Design
- Monitoring and Evaluation
- Academic Grant Writing
- Presenting and Public Speaking
- Top Secret Clearance
- Relationship Management